HAVING DIFFICULT CONVERSATIONS

Moderator Guide | Ranger Mastery Program - Day 11

A conversation about clear intent, respectful honesty, and useful next steps.

Audience: Support Engineers, Rangers, Escalation Engineers, Technical Leads

Suggested duration: 90 minutes | 6-10 participants
Conversation only | No written activities

1. Top learnings and conversation purpose

RMP Day 11 | Week 3: Set boundaries. Explore difficult support conversations, inspired by Marlene Chism's Having Difficult Conversations.

Learning objectives - through conversation, participants will:

Recognize avoidance: explore what makes a conversation difficult and what delay costs the customer, the team, or the relationship.

Prepare with purpose: separate observations from assumptions and clarify a useful outcome before opening the discussion.

Understand the other view: consider competing priorities, work styles, authority, and the influence of power.

Stay clear under pressure: discuss how to name impact and expectations while listening and preserving respectful boundaries.

Make progress explicit: identify an appropriate next step, decision owner, and review point without forcing agreement.

Expected outcome

Participants leave with a shared view of difficult conversations as purposeful work, not a contest or a test of courage. They hear ways to address an issue early, remain curious, and make expectations clear within their role. There are no written tasks, simulations, worksheets, tests, or required follow-up assignments.

Suggested 90-minute conversation

Time	Conversation topic	Question at its heart
0-8	Welcome, objectives, and opening round	Which conversations do we tend to postpone?
8-20	1. Notice avoidance and name the purpose	What makes us postpone a necessary support conversation, and what happens while we wait?
20-32	2. Prepare facts, impact, and a request	What should we clarify before raising a concern with a customer or colleague?
32-44	3. Understand differences and power	How do priorities, roles, and power change what feels safe to say?
44-56	4. Be direct without making it personal	What helps a difficult message stay clear without becoming an accusation?
56-68	5. Respond to resistance and rising tension	What can we do when a reasonable concern is met with defensiveness or pushback?
68-80	6. Close with an understood next step	How do we know a difficult conversation produced something useful?
80-90	Key takeaways and lessons learned	What changed or expanded our thinking?

Use: a flexible route, not a questionnaire to finish. Open with one question and choose follow-ups as needed. Examples are conversation starters, not exercises. The six topics are original support adaptations, not the source's chapter structure.

2. Conversation: purpose and preparation

Topic 1 | Notice avoidance and name the purpose - 8-20 min

Learning objective: Distinguish a useful conversation from venting or winning an argument.

Open the conversation: *"What makes us postpone a necessary support conversation, and what happens while we wait?"*

Follow the conversation:

- What concern makes the first sentence difficult: conflict, hierarchy, uncertainty, or the relationship?
- Who experiences the cost when an unclear expectation remains unspoken?
- What outcome would make the conversation worthwhile even if it is uncomfortable?

If a concrete example helps: A recurring handover gap creates repeated investigation work, but nobody raises it. Ask: What issue needs to be discussed, and what useful change would justify the conversation?

If the discussion drifts: *"Instead of deciding who is difficult, what unresolved issue and desired outcome can we name?"*

Learning point to draw out: Discomfort is not proof that a conversation is wrong. A clear purpose helps address the issue without making the person the problem.

Topic 2 | Prepare facts, impact, and a request - 20-32 min

Learning objective: Enter with a clear account while leaving room for missing context.

Open the conversation: *"What should we clarify before raising a concern with a customer or colleague?"*

Follow the conversation:

- What did we directly observe, and what are we assuming about intent?
- What impact matters to the customer or the work rather than to our frustration?
- What request is specific, proportionate, and within the other person's influence?

If a concrete example helps: An engineer describes a team as unresponsive after two missed updates. Ask: Which agreed times, actual observations, and customer impacts can be discussed without claiming to know the team's motives?

If the discussion drifts: *"Let us replace the label with an observation, an impact, and a question we still need answered."*

Learning point to draw out: Preparation is not building a prosecution. Clear observations and a useful request create space to understand and act.

3. Conversation: listening and clarity

Topic 3 | Understand differences and power - 32-44 min

Learning objective: Explore context and hierarchy without treating them as excuses or making challenge unsafe.

Open the conversation: *"How do priorities, roles, and power change what feels safe to say?"*

Follow the conversation:

- What might the other person be accountable for that we have not considered?
- How can we check our understanding before defending our own position?
- When would a private discussion, a manager, or another approved route be more appropriate?

If a concrete example helps: A senior colleague requests an update cadence that prevents focused diagnosis. Ask: How could an engineer explore the need behind that cadence and raise the trade-off without publicly challenging status?

If the discussion drifts: *"What difference in responsibilities or authority could explain the tension, and how can we explore it respectfully?"*

Learning point to draw out: Curiosity improves understanding; it does not require surrendering a concern. Hierarchy and psychological safety affect the right setting and route.

Topic 4 | Be direct without making it personal - 44-56 min

Learning objective: Discuss language that is honest about impact and open to response.

Open the conversation: *"What helps a difficult message stay clear without becoming an accusation?"*

Follow the conversation:

- How can we describe a behavior without labeling someone's character?
- What is the difference between acknowledging emotion and agreeing with every claim?
- How can we invite a response without weakening a necessary expectation?

If a concrete example helps: A customer repeatedly interrupts a scope discussion. Ask: What wording could acknowledge urgency, explain the need to finish clarifying impact, and invite the customer's most important concern?

If the discussion drifts: *"We do not need the perfect script. What must be clear, and what would make room for a response?"*

Learning point to draw out: Respectful honesty combines clarity with listening. Avoiding the issue entirely can be as unhelpful as delivering it harshly.

4. Conversation: pressure and next steps

Topic 5 | Respond to resistance and rising tension - 56-68 min

Learning objective: Keep disagreement useful without requiring immediate compliance or tolerating abuse.

Open the conversation: *"What can we do when a reasonable concern is met with defensiveness or pushback?"*

Follow the conversation:

- What question might reveal a misunderstanding or a constraint behind the response?
- How do we know whether to continue, pause, or seek an appropriate decision?
- What boundary remains important even when the other person is upset?

If a concrete example helps: A colleague says a request for better handover detail is unfair criticism. Ask: How could the discussion return to continuity and missing information, while recognizing workload and avoiding a debate about intent?

If the discussion drifts: *"Before repeating the request more loudly, what concern or constraint have we not understood?"*

Learning point to draw out: Resistance is information to explore, not proof of bad intent. Pausing or using an approved escalation route can be a responsible next step.

Topic 6 | Close with an understood next step - 68-80 min

Learning objective: Make progress visible without pretending every issue is resolved.

Open the conversation: *"How do we know a difficult conversation produced something useful?"*

Follow the conversation:

- What has been agreed, and what remains unresolved?
- Who can authorize the next decision, and who has accepted the next action?
- When and through which normal channel will the outcome be revisited?

If a concrete example helps: Two teams accept the need for clearer handovers but disagree about capacity. Ask: What can be clarified now, what needs a manager's decision, and what would make the next review meaningful?

If the discussion drifts: *"Rather than force a happy ending, what is the honest next action, owner, or decision route?"*

Learning point to draw out: A useful close can be a clear request, accepted action, or appropriate escalation. It need not be agreement about everything.

5. Moderator's guide: keep it a conversation

Set the tone: opening eight minutes

Introduce the objectives and expected outcome. Say: "This is a conversation, not an assessment. Different roles and regions will see this differently. Use fictional or anonymized work patterns, not customer details. You can pass, and I will make room for each voice."

Use a short opening round: *"Which support conversations are easiest to postpone: expectations, handovers, quality concerns, or competing priorities? A phrase is enough."* Invite everyone once, allowing about 20-30 seconds each. Do not solve each case. Name one or two shared themes, then move to Topic 1.

Make participation broad, not forced

Aim for 6-10 participants. With a larger group, use more round tables or allow more time. Rotate the first voice, invite different roles and shifts, and allow silence for thought. Everyone receives a genuine invitation, not an obligation to disclose or defend their ability.

What you notice	A useful moderator phrase
The same people answer first	"Thank you. Before adding more, let us hear from someone who has not spoken on this topic."
A quieter participant has not had space	"Would you like to add a view from your role or shift? Passing is completely fine."
A speaker runs long	"Let me pause there to make room for others. What is the main point you want us to take from that?"
The conversation becomes a detailed case review	"We do not need to retry that conversation. What purpose, assumption, or expectation does the pattern reveal?"
A person or region is blamed	"Let us examine work conditions and behaviors, not judge a person or team. What would help any engineer here?"
Participants disagree	"What is each view protecting, and what do we understand differently after hearing both?"
Discussion moves to an unrelated issue	"That matters. Can we connect it to today's question, or leave it for the appropriate channel?"
There is silence	"Take a moment. Would the fictional support example help? What might be difficult in that situation?"

Bridge between topics

Reflect neutrally: "I am hearing [theme], with a different experience around [difference]. Have I understood? That connects to our next question about [next topic]." Do not manufacture agreement. Skip optional follow-ups if time is short rather than rush the closing round.

Boundaries: arrange live-queue coverage and follow normal incident and safety procedures. No customer identifiers, raw logs, credentials, personal health disclosures, or live technical changes. Acknowledge sensitive personal concerns and offer the appropriate private support route; do not investigate them in the round table. Performance management, harassment, and conduct complaints belong in the appropriate formal or private channels.

6. Close: key takeaways and lessons learned

Key takeaways to connect back to the objectives

- Start with a useful purpose. Address the issue early rather than judging who is difficult.
- Prepare observations, impact, and a clear request; keep assumptions open to correction.
- Explore differences in priorities and power. Listening is not automatic agreement.
- Stay honest and respectful. Pause or use approved routes when the exchange is unsafe or unproductive.
- Close with clarity about the next step, authority, ownership, and what remains unresolved.

Lessons-learned conversation: minutes 80-87

Invite a brief closing round, with the option to pass: *"What is one idea you are taking away, or one colleague's perspective that changed or expanded your thinking?"* Keep contributions short so everyone has space. No writing or public commitment is required.

If helpful, ask: *"Where might this help in daily support work?"* or *"What still needs team or leadership support?"* Reflect actual participant insights, not anticipated outcomes.

Examples to help the moderator recognize learning

A participant might say...	Connection to the learning objective
"I was avoiding a conversation about an expectation, not a difficult person."	Purpose: identify the issue and the cost of leaving it unspoken.
"A missed update was observable; not caring was my interpretation."	Preparation: separate facts, impact, and assumptions.
"We could agree on the next decision without agreeing about the past."	Progress: clarify the next step without forced consensus.

Moderator wrap-up: minutes 87-90

Summarize two or three themes heard, acknowledge differences, and return to the objectives. Do not promise actions you cannot authorize.

Closing thought: *"A difficult conversation succeeds when it makes the issue clearer and the next step more responsible, not when one person wins."*

Source and adaptation note

Inspired by Marlene Chism, Having Difficult Conversations (1h 3m), assigned for RMP Day 11. The public course overview and visible contents were reviewed November 10, 2026; the complete course was not reviewed. Questions, examples, and moderator guidance are original support adaptations, not a reproduction of the course's model or scripts.

RMP program materials | Course overview